

Letters Across the Slow Train Line

Original sample PDF for Task 15 RAG Parameter Exploration

Fictional, public, non-private, and designed for chunking/retrieval experiments.

1. Baseline Facts for Retrieval Tests

This document is fictional and original. It is not a retelling of any existing film, novel, or anime. The story uses common coming-of-age themes: childhood friendship, letters, distance, trains, seasons, and the quiet difficulty of growing up.

Main characters: Raka Pradipta, Maya Salsabila, and Nara Wicaksana. Raka is careful with words and likes drawing railway maps. Maya is patient, observant, and keeps pressed flowers inside notebooks. Nara is Raka's classmate in high school and later becomes the person who notices Raka's emotional distance before Raka understands it himself.

Key places: Kota Liris, Senja Elementary School, Platform 3 of Liris Station, Kiyora Town, North Aruna Middle School, the old tamarind tree near the river path, and the hill behind Kiyora Library.

Important objects: a blue tin pencil case, a red scarf, a stack of 47 letters, a folded railway map, a paper bookmark with a rain stain, and a brass station clock that stopped at 17:42 during a power outage.

Important dates: Raka and Maya first speak on 17 July 2014. Maya moves away on 29 March 2016. Their first letter is posted on 6 April 2016. Their planned reunion happens on 12 February 2018 during heavy rain and delayed trains. Raka writes his final unsent letter on 3 December 2023.

RAG parameter names intentionally included for search tests: `CHUNK_SIZE`, `TOP_K_INITIAL`, `FINAL_TOP_M`, `USE_RERANKER`, `TEMPERATURE`, and `GROQ_MODEL`. These names appear in the story guide so exact keyword retrieval can be compared with semantic retrieval.

Recommended baseline questions: Who owns the blue tin pencil case? What happened on 12 February 2018? How many letters were kept? Where did Maya place pressed flowers? Why is the brass station clock important?

2. First Meeting at Senja Elementary

Raka met Maya during the first week of grade five at Senja Elementary School. The classroom windows faced a row of rain trees, and every afternoon the leaves made shifting shadows across the blackboard. Raka had transferred from another district because his mother started working at Liris General Hospital. He arrived with a blue tin pencil case, two sharpened pencils, and a habit of sitting near the door so he could leave quickly when the bell rang.

Maya sat by the window. She was not loud, but everyone noticed that she remembered small things. If a classmate forgot lunch money, she knew which teacher kept emergency biscuits. If someone lost a ruler, she remembered who borrowed it the day before. When the class was asked to draw a map of the neighborhood, Maya drew the route from school to the river path, while Raka drew every railway line he knew, even the abandoned freight spur behind Liris Station.

Their first conversation happened because Raka dropped his pencil case. It opened on the floor with a sound sharp enough to make the class turn around. Maya helped him collect the pencils and noticed a tiny paper map folded under the eraser. She did not laugh. She asked, 'Does the line really split after Platform 3?' Raka looked surprised because nobody in class had ever asked about platforms. He answered carefully, 'Only for the evening freight train, and only when the signal is green.'

After that day, they walked home together twice a week until the river bridge. Maya told stories about clouds and the names she invented for them. Raka told her which trains were late most often. They shared no dramatic promise at first. Their friendship grew from ordinary repetition: waiting under the same roof during rain, trading library cards, copying homework instructions, and silently knowing when the other wanted company.

By the end of grade five, their classmates had started calling them the station pair. Raka pretended to dislike the nickname, but he kept a sketch in his notebook titled Platform 3, River Path, Two Shadows. Maya saw the title once and only smiled. The sketch became important later because Raka mailed a copy of it with his seventh letter.

3. The Plan That Failed Before Middle School

During grade six, Raka and Maya planned to attend the same middle school. The plan was simple: North Liris Middle School was close to both their homes, the uniform was blue, and the library had a window seat that Maya wanted to claim before anyone else. Raka made a timetable showing how they could walk from school to Liris Station in eleven minutes if they used the narrow alley behind the stationery shop.

The plan changed in January 2016. Maya's father, who repaired weather instruments for the regional airport, received a transfer to Kiyora Town. Kiyora was not impossibly far, but for two children it felt like a different country. It required a local train, a transfer at Aruna Junction, and then a bus that stopped near the old market only four times a day. Maya heard the news before lunch and said nothing until the last class ended.

Raka found her by the river path, standing under the tamarind tree. She had a red scarf around her neck because the wind was cold. He asked whether the transfer was certain. Maya nodded. She did not cry at first. She only said that North Liris Middle School would not accept a student living outside the district. Raka unfolded his timetable and stared at it as if a different route might appear if he looked long enough.

They made a replacement plan. They would write letters every week. They would save train tickets. They would meet once during the first winter break after middle school started. Maya promised to send pressed flowers from Kiyora's library hill. Raka promised to send station maps and sketches. The promises sounded practical enough to be believable, which made them more painful.

Maya moved on 29 March 2016. Raka went to Liris Station with his mother, but he stood behind a vending machine when Maya's family arrived. He thought he would wave when the train left. Instead, when Maya looked back from the carriage door, he lowered his eyes and pretended to tie his shoelace. Maya saw him anyway. Later she wrote that she had not been angry. She wrote that some goodbyes become too large for the body, so the body

chooses a smaller task, like tying a shoelace.

4. Letters, Weather, and the Slow Change of Distance

The first letter arrived on 9 April 2016, although Maya posted it on 6 April. The envelope smelled faintly of paper dust and rain. Inside was a pressed violet from the hill behind Kiyora Library. Maya wrote about her new classroom, the train line visible from the sports field, and a classmate who always hummed while solving math problems. She ended with one sentence that Raka read many times: 'The sky here is wider, but I do not know where to put the extra space.'

Raka answered with a drawing of Platform 3 and a timetable copied from the station board. His handwriting was stiff because he rewrote the letter three times. He wanted to say he missed her, but wrote instead that the evening freight train now passed at 18:13 instead of 18:07. Maya understood the translation. In her second letter she wrote, 'I miss the old sound too.'

For the first year, the letters came steadily. Maya numbered hers in the corner. Raka did the same after letter five. By December 2016, they had exchanged 23 letters. By August 2017, the number reached 41. Raka kept all of Maya's letters in the blue tin pencil case after removing the pencils. Maya tied Raka's letters with white thread and kept them inside a biscuit tin under her desk.

The subjects of the letters changed slowly. At first they wrote about teachers, homework, the taste of cafeteria curry, train delays, and the exact color of the evening sky. Later the letters carried longer pauses. Maya wrote about feeling tired after joining the astronomy club. Raka wrote about losing a district art competition and pretending it did not matter. They still shared details, but the details had to travel farther before they reached the right feeling.

The forty-seventh letter became the last one before their reunion. Maya wrote it on 28 January 2018. She enclosed a paper bookmark with a rain stain and asked whether Raka still remembered the tamarind tree near the river path. Raka answered on 2 February, but he never mailed the response. Instead, he kept it in his school bag because they had already planned to meet on 12 February 2018.

5. The Reunion During Delayed Trains

The plan for 12 February 2018 looked precise. Raka would leave Liris Station at 14:20, transfer at Aruna Junction at 15:05, and reach Kiyora Town at 16:10. Maya would wait at the old market bus stop wearing the red scarf. They would walk to Kiyora Library, climb the hill, and place their old letters under the wooden bench for a photograph. Raka copied the route into his folded railway map and checked it every hour the night before.

Rain began before noon. By 13:40 the station speakers announced delays on the Aruna line because of a signal failure near East Rindang. Raka's 14:20 train left at 14:58. He missed the 15:05 transfer and waited at Aruna Junction while rainwater moved in silver lines across the platform tiles. At 16:27, the power flickered. The brass station clock stopped at 17:42 and did not move again for the rest of the evening.

Maya waited at the bus stop longer than she had planned. The old market closed, the vegetable sellers covered their baskets, and the last school bus left. She held the red

scarf with both hands because the wind kept loosening it. She had brought the biscuit tin of letters in a canvas bag. At 18:30, an old woman from the tea stall told her the hill path would be muddy and unsafe after dark. Maya stayed anyway.

Raka arrived in Kiyora at 19:18. The bus to the old market had stopped running. He walked for forty minutes through rain, following street lamps and the map that had begun to tear at the fold. When he reached the bus stop, Maya was there, not under dramatic moonlight, not perfectly framed, but tired, soaked, and real. For several seconds neither of them moved. Then Maya laughed first because Raka's hair was flat against his forehead.

They did not say the perfect things. Raka apologized for being late. Maya said the rain was not his fault. Raka said he should have mailed the forty-eighth letter. Maya said she had brought all forty-seven anyway. They walked to the library hill but did not climb to the bench because the path had turned to mud. Instead they sat inside the closed bus shelter and opened the biscuit tin.

Raka expected the reunion to repair the distance. It did not. It gave the distance a shape. They read parts of old letters aloud and discovered that some sentences still sounded alive while others belonged completely to the children who wrote them. Maya found the sketch titled Platform 3, River Path, Two Shadows and touched the corner as if checking whether paper could remember skin.

At 21:05, Maya's father arrived in a small white car. He had been looking for her after the tea stall owner called the house. Before leaving, Maya gave Raka the paper bookmark with the rain stain. Raka gave her the folded railway map. They promised to write again, but both understood that the promise had changed. It was no longer a bridge. It was a lantern left on the bank.

6. High School, Nara, and the Problem of Looking Forward

High school began with new uniforms, new classrooms, and the feeling that everyone else had received instructions Raka had missed. He joined the art club but drew mostly stations, empty roads, and telephone wires. Maya wrote only three letters during the first year after the reunion. Raka answered two. The third remained inside his drawer because he could not decide whether a short answer was honest or cruel.

Nara Wicaksana sat behind Raka in literature class. She was direct in a way that made silence difficult. When the teacher asked students to describe a place that felt like home, Raka wrote about Platform 3 without naming why. Nara read his paragraph during peer review and said, 'This sounds like waiting, not home.' Raka disliked the comment because it was accurate.

Nara became Raka's friend because she did not ask for the whole story at once. She asked practical questions first: why he always checked train schedules, why he kept a paper bookmark in his wallet, why he never submitted drawings with people facing forward. Raka answered with fragments. Nara did not try to fix them. She only said that fragments were still evidence.

In 2020, during a school festival, Nara asked Raka whether he wanted to enter the illustration contest with a piece that included a face. Raka said he was bad at faces. Nara replied that he was not bad at faces; he was afraid of choosing where the eyes

should look. That sentence stayed with him longer than he admitted.

Raka never stopped caring about Maya. But caring became less like a road and more like weather: present, changing, impossible to hold in place. Maya entered a science program in Kiyora. She sent a postcard showing the observatory dome and wrote that she had learned to identify Orion without a chart. Raka placed the postcard beside the bookmark and did not answer for two months.

7. The Last Unsent Letter

On 3 December 2023, Raka wrote a final letter he did not send. He wrote it after seeing a train pass behind the university studio where he worked part-time. The sound made him think of Senja Elementary, the tamarind tree, the rain at Kiyora, and the clock stopped at 17:42. He wrote that he had once believed distance was an enemy. Now he thought distance was also a measurement: it showed what had grown, what had faded, and what still quietly returned.

He thanked Maya for the letters, the pressed violet, the red scarf at the bus stop, and the patience of waiting even when the trains failed. He apologized for the times he mistook silence for loyalty. He wrote that Nara had taught him to draw faces looking forward. He wrote that he hoped Maya had found a sky where the extra space no longer felt frightening.

Raka folded the letter and placed it inside the blue tin pencil case with the others. The case now held forty-seven letters from Maya, two unsent letters from Raka, one paper bookmark, and the corner of a train ticket from 12 February 2018. He did not call this moving on. He called it making room.

The story ends without a dramatic reunion. Years later, Raka passes through Liris Station and notices that Platform 3 has a new sign. The brass clock has been repaired, but he still remembers the evening it stopped. He stands near the vending machine where he once hid during Maya's departure. This time he does not look down. A train arrives. A train leaves. The platform becomes quiet again, and Raka walks toward the exit.

8. RAG Experiment Guide Embedded in the Document

This section is intentionally included to help compare RAG parameter settings. It repeats important facts in a structured way, which helps test whether retrieval finds the correct chunks or gets distracted by similar details.

Fact A: Raka and Maya first speak because Raka drops a blue tin pencil case in grade five. Fact B: Maya moves to Kiyora Town on 29 March 2016. Fact C: the first letter is posted on 6 April 2016 and arrives on 9 April 2016. Fact D: they exchange 47 letters before the reunion. Fact E: the reunion is planned for 12 February 2018. Fact F: a signal failure near East Rindang delays the train. Fact G: the brass station clock stops at 17:42. Fact H: Maya waits at the old market bus stop with a red scarf and a biscuit tin of letters. Fact I: Raka arrives at Kiyora at 19:18. Fact J: Raka writes a final unsent letter on 3 December 2023.

Questions that should be easy with small chunks: Who had the red scarf? What object held Maya's letters? What model-like object did Raka draw often? When did the clock stop?

Questions that need broader context: Why did the reunion not repair the distance? How

did Raka's understanding of distance change? Why does Nara say Platform 3 sounds like waiting, not home?

Parameter notes: smaller CHUNK_SIZE may isolate facts cleanly but can split emotional context. Larger CHUNK_SIZE may preserve narrative meaning but can include distracting details. Higher TOP_K_INITIAL helps when relevant facts are spread across the document. FINAL_TOP_M controls how many chunks the LLM sees. USE_RERANKER should help when several chunks mention trains, letters, rain, and stations. Low TEMPERATURE is best for factual answers based on this document.